



Wildebeest

Connochaetes mearnsi

▷ BLUE WILDEBEEST

All wildebeest males bellow and snort to retain mating rights, but will fight each other if required. These blue wildebeest (*C. taurinus*) in South Africa have locked horns.



The Serengeti white-bearded wildebeest is on its feet within three to seven minutes of birth, can run at 40mph (65km/h), and migrates up to 1,000miles (1,600km) annually. This is enabled by several physical adaptations. High shoulders, a thick neck, and a large head place the bulk of its weight toward the front, while its back slopes to narrow, muscular hips. Mount this arrangement on long, thin legs and you get a bearded antelope that run effortlessly, sharing a similar build with that of a key predator, the spotted hyena.

Super herd formation

The broad mouth, wide row of incisors, and flexible lips are adapted to grazing on the Serengeti short grass, which is rich in phosphorus. This diet compels the wildebeest to follow short grass growth, which depends

on seasonal rains, leading to spectacular migrations across the Serengeti plains of Kenya and Tanzania. The wildebeest merge with other grazers such as zebra to form a “super herd” of 1.25 million animals—the vast number keeps individuals relatively safe from predators.

At the end of the rainy season, all females become sexually receptive for two to three weeks—but each is fertile for just one day. Males set up small mating territories within the super herd. Most calves are born about eight months later, within a two- to three-week period, and can keep up with the herd within two days.

▽ MASS CROSSING

As many as 5,000 to 10,000 wildebeest may make the perilous crossing of the Mara river in Kenya at a time, but hundreds of Nile crocodiles lie in wait for them.

- ↔ 5–8 ft (1.5–2.4 m)
- ⚖ 265–606 lb (120–275 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Grass
- 🏠 🌿



E. Africa

